

Line Quality

Confidence, control & the ghosting method

Line quality is the single most fundamental skill in drawing. A confident, intentional line communicates structure and authority — a hesitant, wobbly line undermines even a well-observed drawing.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Ghosting Method

Before committing a line, rehearse the motion in the air above the paper — 'ghost' it 3–5 times. Lock your shoulder and elbow, then execute in one smooth motion. This separates planning from execution and eliminates hesitation marks.

Pencil Grip for Lines

Use an overhand grip (pencil resting on the side of the hand) for long gestural lines. Use a tripod grip (like writing) for detail and control. Grip further from the tip for looser, broader strokes; closer for precision.

Pressure & Weight

Vary pressure to create line weight. Light lines recede; dark lines come forward. Start light — you can always darken. Practice tapering lines: heavy in the middle, light at the ends (like a natural brush stroke).

Common Mistakes

1) Re-drawing over a line you don't like — commit and move on. 2) Wrist-only lines — use your whole arm for anything longer than 2 inches. 3) Hairy lines — caused by trying to correct mid-stroke. Ghost more, commit once.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw 50 parallel straight lines freehand. Focus on consistent spacing and pressure.
2. Practice ghosted arcs: point A to point B, ghost 5× then draw. Fill a page.
3. Draw a 2-inch line that tapers from thick to thin in one stroke. Repeat 30×.

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – How to Hold Your Pencil

<https://youtu.be/pMC0Cx3Uk84>

■ Draw a Box – Lesson 1 (Lines)

<https://drawabox.com/lesson/1/1>